

The Great Leap BACKWARD

With the 'Third Alternative' sputtering rather than starting, the options for the Left parties are limited

| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

What goes up must come down. After sending its largest ever contingent to the Lok Sabha in the 2004 general elections, the four Left parties are gradually coming to terms with this old dictum. There's no shortage of rhetoric about the "Third Alternative" but the much-trumpeted dream of constituting a non-Congress and non-BJP government at the Centre after the next Lok Sabha polls now looks like a mirage. The indications were clear at the crucial three-day CPI(M) Central Committee meeting in Kochi last week. It was attended by the entire top crust of CPI(M), including General Secretary Prakash Karat and West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, and was expected to finalise the first blueprint for the Left's possible strategies and alliances for the polls. But any concrete reference to the enigmatic third alternative was conspicuous by its absence in the resolutions passed and the utterances of the CPI(M) leaders.

Karat looked uncharacteristically pragmatic when he declared there would be no repeat of 2004 when the Left gave outside support to the Congress-led UPA to form a government to keep the BJP-led NDA at bay. "In 2009 an anti-BJP, non-Congress government will come to power in Delhi. Our Central Committee will formulate the policy which would help this situation to materialise," said Karat at the rally held after the meet. Perhaps, in order to dispel speculation of a possible Left-Congress understanding

emerging after the coming elections and also to take a tough posture, particularly in Kerala where the Congress is its prime enemy, Karat was particularly hard on the UPA Government. He lashed out at the Indo-US nuclear deal, the crisis in the farm sector leading to farmer suicides, and alleged a Rs 1-lakh-crore scam in issuing telecom spectrum licences. Though the political resolution presented at the Central Committee meeting reiterated the need to form a non-Congress, non-BJP government, leaders were hard put to explain the roadmap. Asked about the party's post-election plans, prominent CPI(M) leader Sitaram Yechury stated: "I am a politician and not an astrologer to predict the future."

It is clear now that the Left is pinning its hopes on playing kingmaker again. Already, there is talk that the Left may go for an encore of 2004 if there is no other way to keep the BJP out. The fine distinction drawn by Karat about the new government to be formed as "anti-BJP" but "non-Congress" too is not to be missed. The CPI(M), however, has also many die-hard optimists who hope for a repeat of the United Front government formed by non-Congress and non-BJP

MAYAWATI'S UNPREDICTABILITY HAS PUT THE LEFT IN A SPOT AND HAS GOT IT THINKING OF NEW STRATEGIES

"We are talking and have identified common issues."

SITARAM YECHURY
CPI(M)

